SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #14 · DEBT AND SHAME

“I don't deserve anything nice.”

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Where it often comes from

After debt, many people punish themselves: no vacations, no new clothes, no small pleasures, even when there is room for them. Messages that equated owing money with guilt, a parent who said “we can’t afford joy,” or religious teaching that confused simplicity with suffering can all feed this belief. It can also grow after a mistake that cost the family.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks how God, who did not spare His own Son but gave Him up for us all, will not also freely give us all things. Every good and perfect gift is from above. The psalmist says the Lord withholds no good thing from those who walk with integrity. Ecclesiastes says that it is a gift of God to enjoy the fruit of our labor. None of this is a call to overspend. It means that wise self-denial and gratitude are different from self-punishment.

> *“He who did not spare His own Son but gave Him up for us all, how will He not also, along with Him, freely give us all things?”* (Romans 8:32).

Also see

> “For the LORD God is a sun and a shield; the LORD gives grace and glory; He withholds no good thing from those who walk with integrity” (Psalm 84:11).

> “Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, with whom there is no change or shifting shadow” (James 1:17).

> “Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy” (1 Timothy 6:17).

> “And also that every man should eat and drink and find satisfaction in all his labor—this is the gift of God” (Ecclesiastes 3:13).

Common self-statements

- After what I did, I do not get nice things.
- I should suffer until the debt is paid.
- Enjoying anything would be selfish.
- My family should do without because of me.
- I have to earn the right to be happy.
- Small pleasures are a waste.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must deprive myself.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I deserve punishment.
- Magnification: Making one mistake bigger than it is.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I must either spend freely or have no joy at all.

Challenging questions

- Is my self-denial a wise plan or a punishment?

- What would I want for a friend in my situation?
- What does God's gift of His Son say about what He wants to give me?
- What small, inexpensive joys could I accept without guilt?
- Who is helped by my suffering?
- What is the difference between being careful and being cruel to myself?

Truth summary

> Wisdom with money is good. Self-punishment is not. God gives good gifts, and I can receive small joys with thanks while still keeping a sensible budget. I do not have to earn the right to be cared for.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Thankful
- Love, By God
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I don't deserve anything nice"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I don't deserve anything nice." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where am I punishing myself?
- ☐ What would I want for a friend?
- ☐ What small joy could I accept this week?
- ☐ What does God's gift of His Son say about me?
- ☐ How is a budget different from punishment?
- ☐ What good gift can I thank God for today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Wise limits are different from self-punishment.
- ☐ God gives good gifts.
- ☐ I can enjoy simple things with thanks.
- ☐ My suffering does not pay the debt.
- ☐ I am worth caring for.
- ☐ Gratitude and budgeting can live together.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:32
  "He who did not spare His own Son but gave Him up for us all, how will He not also, along with Him, freely give us all things?"
- ☐ Psalm 84:11
  "For the LORD God is a sun and a shield; the LORD gives grace and glory; He withholds no good thing from those who walk with integrity."
- ☐ James 1:17
  "Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, with whom there is no change or shifting shadow."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A gift I received: Each day, write down one small good thing you accepted with thanks and note whether guilt showed up.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Romans 8:32 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God gave His Son for me, so I can receive small gifts with thanks.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Thankful" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Plan one small, free or low-cost joy. A walk, a call with a friend, a favorite meal at home. Put it on the calendar.
- [ ] Separate budget from punishment. Write what your budget actually requires, and notice any extra rules you added.
- [ ] Practice receiving. When someone offers a kindness, say "thank you" without explaining or refusing.
- [ ] Thank God for one gift each day. Name it aloud.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I don't deserve anything nice": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A gift I received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I don't deserve anything nice.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You gave Your Son for me, and You are a giver of good gifts. Heal the place in me that says I do not deserve any good. Teach me to be wise and thankful, and to receive Your care. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.